

MGT 409: LEADING IN NETWORKS AND ORGANIZATIONS

WINTER WEEKEND INTENSIVE 2026 (JAN 24-25 & FEB 21-22)

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DESCRIPTION

Why do some organizations succeed but others fail? And what can be done about it? The answers to these questions are consequential to your professional success because, regardless of career choice, people spend most of their lives as part of one organization or another. Building on lessons from prior leadership and team management courses, MGT 409 explores major determinants of a firm's success or failure, and how to manage challenging organizational dynamics. Topics include social and professional networks, organizational networks and information exchange in markets, equity and inclusion, organizational culture and innovation, organizational design, corruption, organizational scandals, and fostering change in firms.

Instructional methods. To translate theory into practice, this course is taught in an applied manner. Class sessions are structured around group exercises that allow you to engage with and experience relevant course concepts firsthand. Exercises are followed by instructor-facilitated group discussions of illustrative case studies and evidence-based insights generated by behavioral and management scientists, which contextualize your experiences and ground course concepts in real organizational settings. Due to the highly condensed nature of this class, there is also time built-in to work on a mini capstone final project that will help you apply what you learn in real time.

OBJECTIVES

The central learning objective is to provide you with an organizational strategy toolkit, which can be used throughout your career. By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Identify important characteristics of your social and professional network and understand how to leverage your network to benefit your career and your firm
- Identify the major contributing factors to an organization's success or failure, and critically analyze/diagnose these processes in real organizations
- Develop evidence-based solutions to challenging organizational dynamics and effectively communicate your insights and strategies

REQUIRED MATERIALS

All course materials are available on Canvas. Please note that slide decks uploaded to Canvas after each class will not include all details of exercises and cases due to copyrights.

Technology Policy. Please bring a computer or tablet to class. Many in-class exercises require running a software program or accessing an online platform. Please reach out as soon as possible if you anticipate having an issue consistently accessing a laptop or tablet, and we will find a work-around. All class sessions are video recorded, and recordings are uploaded to Canvas (see Panopto tab). Due to copyrights for the cases and exercises used in this class, other videotaping and audio recording is prohibited unless approved by Rady administrators.

Class Policy for use of Generative AI: This policy applies to use of various new generative AI tools that can generate text, images, etc., in response to prompts by users (e.g., ChatGPT, BingChat, Bard, Midjourney, etc.). These new tools and programs have considerable potential to streamline and augment our work. You are permitted to use these tools for this class, with several caveats and conditions:

1. These tools should augment your work, not replace it. For instance, large language models can provide help improving the quality of your writing, identify new sources, get high-level summaries of complex ideas or terms, or pressure test your arguments for logical inconsistencies. These tools can help you get started on idea, help overcome writer's block, or refine YOUR original ideas. These tools should not be used generate content that you simply put your name on. This constitutes an academic integrity violation, much like taking another individual's work and misrepresenting it as your own original work (see end of syllabus for details on UCSD's academic integrity policy). Moreover, such an approach is likely to lead to low quality responses and low scores because these tools often produce rudimentary and superficial analysis.
2. If you use generative AI for an assignment, be transparent about if/how it was used in a footnote or citation. Using generative AI tools without attributing credit will be treated as comparable to failing to properly credit and cite/reference other people's contributions and sources used in your work.
3. Large language models have documented issues with hallucination and inaccuracy (e.g., generating fake citations, failing logical arguments, misrepresenting sources, etc.). You are fully responsible for the content you submit in your assignments and will be graded accordingly.
4. Overreliance on generative AI tools, specifically in the form of using it to "think" for you, is shown to be associated with brain atrophy (see MIT Media Lab study [here](#)). The way to avoid this is to engage in your own critical thinking first and then use generative AI tools to help refine your original ideas. Keep this in mind!

SCHEDULE AND COURSE FORMAT

A schedule with details on topics, exercises, cases, and assignments is available on Canvas and at the end of this syllabus. Due to the exercise- and group discussion-based format of this class, in-person attendance is critical to your and your classmates' learning experience. This class cannot employ a hybrid format because it is too logistically challenging for students to complete in-class exercises with a combination of group members attending in person and remotely.

Weekend Intensive format: Due to the intensive format of this class, attendance is critical. Missing one day, especially the first weekend, is equivalent to missing 25-30% of the course content.

ASSIGNMENTS

Your course grade includes individual assignments, class participation, an open-book quiz, and a final group project. An overview of each assignment is included in the table below and more details are provided on the following pages and Canvas.

Assignments*	Scoring
Class Engagement Holistic assessment of engagement in class, including attendance, engagement in group exercises, participation in class-wide discussions, and peer evaluations. Scored individually.	25 pts
Exit Polls & Peer Evaluation 1-2 sentence reflections always due within 1 day of end of class session. Scored individually (1pt/each). 7 exit polls & 1 peer evaluation due at the end of the term (1pt).	8 pts
Thought Questions Responses to 2 short-answer questions. Scored individually (10 pts/each).	20 pts
Open-book Quiz Open-book, take-home quiz. Scored individually.	25 pts
Group Project: Real World Case Analysis Postmortem analysis of a real organizational challenge or failure event & a proposed do-over strategy. Deliverables include a written memo and in-class presentation. Group grades.	60 pts
Total	138 pts

Class Engagement (individual grade). Everyone's learning experience benefits from high-quality discussions and active engagement in class exercises, so we should all contribute by participating in class. Your participation score is a holistic assessment that takes several things into account:

- **Attendance:** Due to the number of in-class group exercises and discussions, this course cannot accommodate a hybrid format (see course format section for more information). Attending class in person is important for your and your classmates' learning experience. Attendance is also crucial considering the condensed format of this class. ***But do not come to class if you are sick!*** You will never be penalized for missing class due to illness or other extenuating circumstances beyond your control. If you will be missing a

class, please reach out to me as soon as possible so we can work out an alternative plan for you to earn participation credit.

- **In-class participation:** This includes preparing for, actively participating in, and thoughtfully contributing to group discussions, group exercises, and class-wide discussions. The quality of your contributions is more important than the quantity of your contributions.
- **Canvas discussion board participation:** In-class participation is not the only way that you can contribute. You can also participate by posting to the discussion boards on Canvas. As an example, a good contribution would be posting a link to an article that illustrates a relevant course concept and briefly commenting.
- **Peer evaluations:** You will be asked to complete a survey at the end of the course that asks you about how you see each other as contributors and participants in class, which I will use to augment my personal assessment. You will also receive credit for completing these evaluations (1pt, separate assignment).

Exit Polls (individual grade). At the end of several modules, you will briefly reflect on what concepts from that class session you found most interesting and what is still confusing, if anything. These exit polls provide me with information about the class's progress and what concepts need to be reviewed. Reflecting at the end of a class session has also been shown to significantly improve retention of the information. Answers should be 1-2 sentences and completed within 24 hours of the end of the class session (each response is scored complete/incomplete).

Thought Questions (individual grade). There are 2 Thought Question responses due throughout the quarter. The goal of this assignment is to reflect on your intuition, educated opinions, and beliefs about handling organizational challenges, managing various workplace situations, or making career decisions, and what information has led you to form these opinions. For instance, you might be asked to consider a hypothetical workplace scenario and what decisions you would make or how you would handle certain challenges. This helps you draw direct links between course concepts and your personal experiences. This assignment provides a foundation for discussing new evidence and learnings on these same topics during class, which might support or challenge your current beliefs and opinions. When writing these responses, I recommend keeping the following in mind:

- Responses should articulate a clear perspective/argument and be supported by evidence. There are no incorrect stances or positions, but you are graded on how clearly you articulate that position and the evidence you are drawing upon to justify that position. Simply stating your opinion without evidence will result in a low score. You can incorporate traditional and anecdotal evidence like personal experiences, learnings from this class or other courses, advice from peers or mentors, evidence from reliable sources online (e.g., news articles, articles written by experts, white papers), assigned or supplemental class readings, etc. Please always include citations for your references, which are not included in the overall word count.
- Responses are always due before the start of class session to ensure you have considered these important course concepts before we discuss them in class.
- Responses should be concise and generative for in-class discussions (max of 300 words in total). While we are not draconian about word limits in our grading, excessively long responses will not receive high scores. Students who repeatedly violate the word count excessively will be penalized because this represents a fairness issue.

- Although you are always welcome to discuss course material with your classmates, these responses must be written individually.
- See Canvas for some anonymized examples from prior classes.

Open-book Quiz (individual grade). To demonstrate your individual ability to apply course concepts to real workplace challenges you encounter, you will complete one open-book quiz individually. There are no timelines for when the quiz must be completed, so you can complete it on your own time. All quiz questions will be made available for ~1 week and responses must be submitted by the assigned deadline. Additional information about the quiz and grading rubric will be made available in class and on Canvas.

Group Project: Real World Case Analysis (group grade). To demonstrate your ability to apply course concepts and communicate evidence-based solutions, you will work on a team to conduct a postmortem analysis of a real organizational challenge or failure event and propose a do-over strategy.

**** I recognize this class schedule is a tight timeline for group projects! Note you will have time to work on this together in class, and part of the goal of this assignment is to do live application of course material. You will be graded on an in-class presentation and a written memo that is not due until end-of-quarter. ****

Because students in this class can come from multiple cohorts, teams assignments will be based on study groups but students from other cohorts will also be randomly assigned. Each team can pick their own topic. I recommend using the following steps as a guide for approaching this group project:

1. **Pick an organizational failure event or challenge that you find interesting.** Feel free to interpret this broadly. Think about a firm that has faced and failed to overcome a competitive challenge, failed in a major or meaningful way, or was embroiled in a scandal. History is full of organizational failures, giving you many possible topics. There is a list of possible topics on Canvas to give you inspiration, but you are not limited to this list. All topics are subject to my final approval. The constraints on topic selection are:
 - It must be an organizational failure and not a single person's failure.
 - It cannot already be covered in a case study discussed in class (see schedule at the end of the syllabus for a list of cases being used in class).
 - The topic must be well enough known that there is sufficient evidence to analyze.
 - No two groups can do the same topic. Once you identify your topic, put it on the sign-up list on Canvas to claim it.

Keep in mind that many organizational failures have had serious consequences for people's lives and livelihoods. Please be respectful of this when selecting your topic and conducting your analysis.

2. **Figure out what happened, why it happened, and what you would have done differently.** I recommend reviewing the final project grading rubric available on Canvas to understand how your project will be evaluated. A compelling postmortem analysis should address the following and be supported by reliable evidence:

- Description/background context: What happened and why is it important for us to understand?
 - Analysis: What were the major contributing factors or catalysts to this failure event, and why?
 - Proposed do-over strategy: Imagine that you have gone back in time and the firm has hired your team as consultants to help them navigate this challenge or failure event in real time. You are encouraged to approach this creatively. For instance, depending on the type of failure event, you could imagine your team was hired just before the failure occurred (i.e., you focus on preventing the failure) or after a failure becomes public (i.e., you focus on improving the firm's post-scandal response). What are your strategic recommendations for how the firm should handle this situation, or could have avoided it altogether? Why will your proposed strategy be successful?
3. **Tell us about your insights.** Write up your analysis and proposed do-over strategy in a memo and present your findings to class.

Written memo: This is a report of your evidence, analysis, insights, and do-over strategy. You can be creative with formatting, and I recommend thinking about the most compelling, informative, and persuasive structure to present this information to the firm's leadership. The memo should not be longer than 2,000 words (equivalent of ~8 pgs double spaced with 12-pt font). Appendices with supplementary evidence, tables/figures, references, brief abstracts, and title pages are excluded from the word count. While we are not draconian about word limits in our grading, excessively long memos will not receive high scores. All memos will be due on March 19.

In-class presentation: Your group will have 10-15 minutes during Weekend 2 to present your findings to your classmates (additional details provided in class). These presentations are intended to be overviews and are not expected to cover everything that is in your written memo. Think critically about what is most important.

Note: While this course frontloads the lion's share of content into Weekend 1, you will be learning course content relevant to your final project through Weekend 2. I understand this is a time crunch and do not expect all content to be integrated into the presentation (but you are welcome to if you'd like). But you are given adequate time to integrate any/all relevant course concepts for the written memo.

GRADING POLICIES

All grading rubrics are on each assignments' page on Canvas. Please review the rubrics in advance of submitting assignments to ensure you include all required information.

Grading. Letter grade conversions follow a traditional approach (e.g., 90.0-93.9% is A-, 94.0-96.9% is A, 97.0% or higher is A+, and so on). I do not negotiate final grades. Please see follow the formal grade appeal policy if you have concerns about a grade you received.

Grade Appeals. To formally appeal a grade you received, please send me an email that explains your position (cc'ing the TA) and the original assignment within 7 days of receiving your grade. I

will review the request and comments provided by the TA. I will either award you with additional points or outline my reasoning for maintaining the same score. I reserve the right to regrade the entire assignment if I think it is necessary to address the disputed issues, which can result in a lower overall grade than the TA originally assigned your submission.

GENERAL CLASS POLICIES

Email. Generally, I respond to emails within ~2 days. This is my personal policy and does not apply to TAs. I don't typically monitor email outside of normal working hours, so response times for emails sent on holidays and weekends will be slower. I check my email more regularly than Canvas messages, so please email me at ecampbell@ucsd.edu if you'd like a prompt response.

Deadline Extensions. I will evaluate requests for deadline extensions on a case-to-case basis. To request an extension, send me an email at least 2 days in advance of the deadline. Deadline extensions will not be granted after the original assignment deadline has passed, and at that point, the Late Assignment Policy applies. Please note I am limited in my ability to provide deadline extensions for final assignments due to the university's grading policies.

Late Assignments. Late assignments will be accepted with penalty if submitted within 3 days of the deadline. I provide a short grace period for Canvas submissions, but beyond that, late submissions are penalized 5% each day they are late. Assignments submitted more than 3 days after the deadline will receive a 0. This is to ensure that students are not still completing assignments that others have received feedback/grades on, which could provide an unfair advantage. Late assignments due to emergencies, illness, or extenuating circumstances beyond your control will be evaluated on a case-by-case basis. It is expected that you contact me prior to the deadline, if possible, to discuss these extenuating circumstances and so we can develop a plan.

Academic Integrity (UC San Diego policy). Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind. The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at [here](#).

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities (UC San Diego policy). A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member. Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities by calling (858) 534-4382 or emailing osd@ucsd.edu. The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.

Health and Well-being. This class is not more important than your physical and psychological health and the well-being of you or your family. Many students deal with a range of challenging

issues that can impact their learning, such as physical illness, housing or food insecurity, financial stress, strained relationships, loss of motivation, depression, anxiety, stress, or grief. If you are dealing with extenuating circumstances or ongoing challenges that impact your ability to attend class or complete assignments, please reach out to me as soon as possible so I can support you. We can develop a plan together that sets you up for success in this class. Below are several resources available to UC San Diego students:

UC San Diego Counseling and Psychological Services (UCSD CaPS)

(p) 858-534-3755 (available 24-7)

(w) <https://caps.ucsd.edu/>

UC San Diego Student Health Services

(p) 858-534-3300

(w) <https://studenthealth.ucsd.edu/>

UC San Diego Health Coaching

(w) <https://healthpromotion.ucsd.edu/services/health-coaching/index.html>

(e) hps@health.ucsd.edu

CLASS SCHEDULE – SEPTEMBER WEEKEND INTENSIVE 2024

WEEKEND 1: JAN 24-25

To-do before Weekend 1:

1. Enroll in Harvard Business & Education course pack to access all readings & many in-class exercises (follow link via email or on Canvas)
2. Enroll in iDecisionGames to access an in-class exercise platform (follow instructions provided in email)
3. Complete Thought Question 1 Response (deadline on Canvas)

To read before Weekend 1:

Read before Saturday of Weekend 1:

1. Heidi Roizen HBS case (must read p.1-11, can skim p.13-17)
2. “Genesis of a high-tech hub” article (read p.1-4)
3. Satya Nadella at Microsoft London Business School case (must read p.1-11, can skim p.12-19)

Read before Sunday of Weekend 1:

4. Read instructions for Evolving Structures exercise
5. Volkswagen emissions scandal INSEAD case (read p.1-21)

SCHEDULE FOR DAY 1 (JAN 24)

Feb 1 Morning (9am-12pm) – Session 1

Introductions

- Lecture on foundations of organizational strategy
- Overview of course structure, major assignments, grading, and expectations

Why who you know still matters (Personal & Professional Networks Module)

- How good are you at networking? (Leveraging Networks in-class exercise, access via Harvard coursepack)
- Crafting your social network & building social capital (Heidi Roizen HBS case discussion & lecture on key networking concepts)

End of session: Complete Personal Networks Module Exit Poll

**** Lunch ****
12-1pm

Feb 1 Afternoon (1-3:30pm) – Session 2

It's not just about you: How your network impacts the firm (Organizational Networks Module)

- Networks as a competitive advantage (LeMontre iDecisionGames in-class exercise, access via iDecisionGames link)
- The lasting impact of organizational networks (San Diego's biotech hub case discussion & lecture)

Complete Organizational Networks Module Exit Poll

Group project time: Meet your group, select a topic, & start planning!

**** Coffee break & Office Hours ****
3:30-4pm

Feb 1 Afternoon (4-6pm) – Session 3

Organizational culture eats strategy for breakfast (Organizational Culture Module)

- What culture boosts innovation? (Organizational culture debate exercise, materials on Canvas)
- Changing a firm's culture (Satya Nadella & Microsoft London Business School case discussion & lecture)

End of session: Complete Organizational Culture Module Exit Poll

Reminders of reading before Sunday of Weekend 1:

1. *Read Evolving Structures exercise instructions (Org Design module)*
2. *Read Volkswagen emission scandal INSEAD case (read p.1-21)*

SCHEDULE FOR DAY 2 (JAN 25)

Feb 2 Morning (9am-12pm) – Session 4

Beyond the convoluted org chart (Organizational Design & Structure Module)

- Unintended consequences of org design (Evolving Structures in-class exercise, access via Harvard coursepack link)
- Exercise debrief & lecture on key concepts

End of session: Completed Org Design Module Exit Poll

**** Lunch ****
12-1pm

Feb 2 Afternoon (1-3:30pm) – Session 5

This is why we can't have nice things: Ethical violations & scandals in firms (Corruption in Networks & Firms Module)

- Things aren't so simple (Excalibur Construction ethical dilemma in-class exercise, materials on Canvas)
- Catalysts to ethical violations in firms (Discussion of Volkswagen emissions scandal & lecture on key concepts)

**** Coffee break & Office Hours ****
3:30-4pm

Feb 2 Afternoon (4-6pm) – Session 6

Organizational corruption & scandals don't

- Discussion of Toyota accelerator scandal & lecture on key concepts relating to navigating organizational scandals

Complete Corruption Module Exit Poll

In-class Group Project Time

- Review of final project presentation, final deliverables, and my recommendations
 - In-class time to work with final project group (complete provided outline to select 2-3 key concepts from weekend 1 that are relevant to your org failure & brainstorm why)
 - Q&A with professor
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End of Weekend 1 Reminders:

- *Please complete your assigned readings & submit your response for Thought Question 2 before Weekend 2 (see Canvas for deadlines)*
- *Take time to work with your final group project team. While you will get time to prepare for your in-class presentation next weekend, I recommend checking in with your project group at least once a week to make sure you're on track for presentations and written memo progress.*

WEEKEND 2: FEB 21-22

To-do before Weekend 2:

1. Be working with your final project group on the in-class presentation (final presentations are afternoon of Day 4)
2. Complete Thought Question 2 Response (deadline on Canvas)

To read before Saturday of Weekend 2:

1. BlackRock HBS case (must read p.7-21, can skim p.1-6)
2. Read instructions for Networking & Influence Simulation Exercise

SCHEDULE FOR DAY 3 (FEB 21)

March 1 Morning Session (9am-12pm) – Session 7

Weekend 1 Concept Review

A moral imperative: Equity & inclusion in firms

- What do we take for granted at work? (Market for Privilege in-class exercise, materials on Canvas)
- Evidence-based practices to boost equity & inclusion in orgs (BlackRock case discussion & lecture)

End of session: Complete Equity & Inclusion Module Exit Poll

**** Lunch ****
12-1pm

March 1 Afternoon Session (1-3:30pm) – Session 8

What you can do about it: Fostering change in firms (Organizational Change Module)

- Change agents in action (Networking and Influence Simulation in-class exercise, materials on Canvas)
- Exercise debrief and lecture on change management principles

End of session: Complete Org Change Module Exit Poll

**** Coffee break & Office Hours ****
3:30-4pm

March 1 Afternoon Session (4-6pm) – Session 9

Wrap-up organizational change lecture

In-class final project presentation prep time

- Class time to work with your group & Q&A with professor

SCHEDULE FOR DAY 4 (FEB 22)

March 2 Morning Session (9am-12pm) – Session 10

Course content review and review of major assignments, deadlines, and end-of-course information

Course evals

In-class time to finalize & practice final project presentations

**** Lunch ****
12-1pm

March 2 Afternoon Session 1 (1-3:30pm) – Session 11

Final project presentations (10-15min/group)

**** Coffee break & Office Hours ****
3:30-4pm

March 2 Afternoon Session 2 (4-6pm) – Session 12

Wrap up final project presentations

Wrap-up discussion & resources for additional learning

END-OF-CLASS DEADLINES

To-do by 11:59pm on Wednesday March 18:

- Complete Peer Evaluations (available on Canvas)
- Submit your final written memo for final project (group grade, only 1 person needs to upload it to Canvas)
- Submit your open-book quiz response (individual grade)